Hope for Humanity-(COVID-19)

By Eavan Boland, Dr. George Young, Dr. Elizabeth Mitchell, Lynn Ungar and Brother Richard Hendrick

NOTE: *Check the publication requirements for your tournament or state before performing. 4 of the 5 poems are available on NSDA approved websites, but may not be considered "published" for your specific tournament.*

Quarantine by Eavan Boland

In the worst hour of the worst season
of the worst year of a whole people
a man set out from the workhouse with his wife.
He was walking – they were both walking – north.

She was sick with ~~famine~~ fever and could not keep up.
He lifted her and put her on his back.
He walked like that west and west and north.
Until at nightfall under freezing stars they arrived.

In the morning they were both found dead.
Of cold. Of hunger. Of the toxins of a whole history.
But her feet were held against his breastbone.
The last heat of his flesh was his last gift to her.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Eavan Boland
Book: Against Love Poetry
ISBN: 978-0393020427
Publisher: W.W. Norton and Company
Date (Month/Year): 2001

INTRODUCTION

Today, in hospitals across the country, the lack of widespread testing and the severe shortage of protective gear have left our doctors and nurses sacrificing their own safety to provide care for the sick. The virus (COVID-19) is as invisible as it is dangerous.

Dr. Rafael Campo states . . . 'When a cure isn't possible... what do we still have to offer our patients? It's our own humanity.' Compassion in the face of overwhelming odds.

Our doctors and our nurses are on the front lines every day. Even the ones working their 2nd or 3rd or 4th shift . . . .

Tell Me by Dr. George Young

Tell me the night silence

on the locked Alzheimer's ward is broken

by a yell from room 206,

that an old man with flattened

nose and crumpled ears,

whose family moved away to Arizona,

whose doctor never comes

to visit, is standing

in the middle of that room, naked,

his freckled face a clenched fist,

urine and feces running

down his legs.

Then tell me that the fat one, twelve

years on the job,

working her second shift because

someone's car won't start,

comes with a pan

of warm water, a sponge and a towel;

how, back in bed, he

cries, You know—

I'm in the ring tomorrow with Killer;

how a tiny smile begins, how

her hand reaches out

to flick down his wild flame of hair.

Now tell me again

why you don't believe in angels.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Dr. George Young
ISBN: NSDA Approved Website
Publisher: LA Times.com
Article Title: Doctor-poets search for the right words to help patients heal
Date (Month/Year): March 11, 2020
Website: https://www.latimes.com/science/story/2020-03-11/column-one-doctor-poets

TRANSITION

Dr. Elizabeth Mitchell explains the fear and anxiety in her emergency department at Boston Medical Center. The uncertainty in the air . . . the physician's protective armor which seems so meager . . . Too meager for The Apocalypse.

The Apocalypse by Dr. Elizabeth Mitchell

This is the apocalypse

A daffodil has poked its head up

from the dirt and opened

sunny arms to bluer skies

yet I am filled with

dark and anxious dread

as theaters close as travel ends and

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grocery stores display their empty rows
where toilet paper liquid bleach
and bags of flour stood in upright ranks.
My stomach twists and fingers shake
as I prepare to work the battleground
the place I've always loved and felt at home
is now a field of droplets sprayed across a room
or lurking on a handle or a sink to find their way
inside our trusting hands or mouths or eyes
the ones that touch you when you're sick
speak soothing words and seek the answer to your
pain.

This is the apocalypse
as spring begins again
and brightly colored flowers
deploy in my back yard
the neighbors walk their dogs
and march along the quiet streets
I stretch my purple gloves on steady hands
I tie my yellow gown behind my back

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my hair inside a blue bouffant
my mouth and nose and eyes are
still and calm inside their waiting shields.
This is the apocalypse

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Dr. Elizabeth Mitchell
ISBN: NSDA Approved Website
Publisher: NYTimes.com
Article Title: The Doctor and 'The Apocalypse'
Date (Month/Year): March 24, 2020
Website:
https://www.nytimes.com/2020/03/24/us/coronavirus-doctor-poetry-boston.html

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TRANSITION

Kitty O'Meara posted the following on her blog "The Daily Round" in March of 2020:

And the people stayed home. And read books, and listened, and rested . . . and made art, and . . . learned new ways of being, and were still . . . And the people began to think differently. And the people healed. And when the danger passed, and the people joined together again, they grieved their losses, and made new choices, and dreamed new images, and created new ways to live.

This time of fear and uncertainty could be humanity's greatest opportunity for growth. If only . . .
https://sweetbreathing.com/and-the-people-stayed-home/2020/16/

Pandemic by Lynn Ungar

What if you thought of it

as the Jews consider the Sabbath —

the most sacred of times?

Cease from travel.

Cease from buying and selling.

Give up, just for now,

on trying to make the world

different than it is.

Sing. Pray. Touch only those

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to whom you commit your life.

Center down.

And when your body has become still,

reach out with your heart.

Know that we are connected

in ways that are terrifying and beautiful.

(You could hardly deny it now.)

Know that our lives

are in one another's hands.

(Surely, that has come clear.)

Do not reach out your hands.

Reach out your heart.

Reach out your words.

Reach out all the tendrils

of compassion that move, invisibly,

where we cannot touch.

Promise this world your love —

for better or for worse,

in sickness and in health,

so long as we all shall live.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Lynn Ungar
ISBN: NSDA Approved Website
Publisher: Chicago Tribune
Article Title: 'Pandemic,' a little-known poet's poem about the coronavirus, goes viral
Date (Month/Year): March 13, 2020
Website:
https://www.chicagotribune.com/columns/mary-schmich/ct-met-schmich-pandemic-poem-20200314-yywfy7th2nbc5cufvnbb7qhvfm-story.html

Lockdown by Brother Richard Hendrick

Yes there is fear.

Yes there is isolation.

Yes there is panic buying.

Yes there is sickness.

Yes there is even death.

But,

They say that in Wuhan after so many years of noise

You can hear the birds again.

They say that after just a few weeks of quiet

The sky is no longer thick with fumes

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But blue and grey and clear.

They say that in the streets of Assisi

People are singing to each other

across the empty squares,

keeping their windows open

so that those who are alone

may hear the sounds of family around them.

They say that a hotel in the West of Ireland

Is offering free meals and delivery to the housebound.

Today a young woman I know

is busy spreading fliers with her number

through the neighbourhood

So that the elders may have someone to call on.

Today Churches, Synagogues, Mosques and Temples

are preparing to welcome

and shelter the homeless, the sick, the weary

All over the world people are slowing down and reflecting

All over the world people are looking at their neighbours

in a new way

All over the world people are waking up to a new reality

To how big we really are.

To how little control we really have.

To what really matters.

To Love.

So we pray and we remember that

Yes there is fear.

But there does not have to be hate.

Yes there is isolation.

But there does not have to be loneliness.

Yes there is panic buying.

But there does not have to be meanness.

Yes there is sickness.

But there does not have to be disease of the soul

Yes there is even death.

But there can always be a rebirth of love.

Wake to the choices you make as to how to live now.

Today, breathe.

Listen, behind the factory noises of your panic

The birds are singing again

The sky is clearing,

Spring is coming,

And we are always encompassed by Love.

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Open the windows of your soul

And though you may not be able

to touch across the empty square,

Sing

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Brother Richard Hendrick
ISBN: NSDA Approved Website
Publisher: Huffington Post
Article Title: Irish Priest Pens Stirring Poem about the Coronavirus Lockdown
Date (Month/Year): March 20, 2020
Website: https://www.huffpost.com/entry/ireland-priest-coronavirus-lockdown-poem_n_5e748a0cc5b6f5b7c541e875